

HARD LINE
Simranjit Mann after his victory in Sangrur, June 26

PRABHJOT GILL

PUNJAB / BYPOLLS

A RADICAL MANN

By Anilesh S. Mahajan

The past year in Punjab politics has been full of surprises. The latest shocker has been the Sangrur Lok Sabha bypoll results where 77-year-old Simranjit Singh Mann came out of nowhere to deliver a stunning blow to the ruling Aam Aadmi Party (AAP). The constituency was represented for two consecutive terms since 2014 by new chief minister Bhagwant Mann; indeed, the bypoll was necessitated after he assumed his new post in March. But Mann, who had lost his deposit in the 2019 election, defeated AAP candidate Gurmail Singh by 5,822 votes.

In the past two decades, Simranjit Mann and his Shiromani Akali Dal (Amritsar) had been pushed to the fringes due to his radical, pro-Khalistan views. Just three months back, AAP had swept the state assembly polls, winning 92 of the 117 seats and Sangrur had been the epicentre of this. AAP had pocketed all nine assembly seats in this Lok Sabha segment. Apart from CM Bhagwant Mann, finance minister Harpal Cheema and school education minister Gurmeet Singh Meet Hayer are also part of this Lok Sabha segment.

Simranjit Mann's last election win came way back in the 1999 Lok Sabha election from Sangrur. A former IPS officer, Mann had quit the service days after Operation Blue Star in 1984. He spent many years in jails across India for his pro-Khalistan stand, and for that reason alone, he is a hero of the hardliners and Khalistan champions. In fact, on June 26, when he was declared winner, he dedicated his victory to slain Khalistani terrorist Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale and also declared that he would raise the issues of Kashmiri militants and Maoists in Parliament. His unapologetic separatist views must already be giving security agencies nightmares. That he now also gets a platform to air these views will no doubt enthuse the pro-Khalistan cohorts in Europe, Canada and elsewhere.

SIMRANJIT MANN'S UNAPOLOGETIC SEPARATIST VIEWS ARE CAUSE FOR WORRY. AS SANGRUR MP, HE NOW ALSO HAS A PLATFORM TO AIR THEM

AAP's prospects in the contest were dented by the low turnout on polling day. The voting percentage was 45.3 per cent, far less than the 72.4 per cent in the 2019 Lok Sabha election and 68 per cent in the March assembly poll. AAP's local cadre were nervous on polling day. In fact, the local administration, allegedly under pressure from CM Bhagwant Mann, extended polling by an hour. The Election Commission has now ordered an inquiry into the issue. Sources say the murder of popular rapper Sidhu Moosewala in broad daylight on May 29 may have also dented AAP's credibility in the region.

For Simranjit Mann—whose supporters call him the real Mann of Punjab—this will be his third time in Parliament. His first win was in 1989, at the peak of militancy, when he and his associates won six of the 13 Lok Sabha seats in Punjab. Mann won the Tarn Taran seat from Bhagalpur (Bihar) jail and was later denied entry into Parliament as he was carrying a long sword as part of Sikh custom (he apparently quit in protest). Ten years later, in 1999, he defeated Akali Dal stalwart